MIŻIEN Claim Check 137 · Climate and energy

Were Malta's July power cuts predictable?

Testing the Malta Chamber's statement on demand, population and investment against NSO and Eurostat data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

"It is evident that the investment carried out was not enough."

Malta Chamber of Commerce, Enterprise and Industry, 21 July 2026.
A statement on the July 2026 power cuts, with no figures.

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED *Foreseeable rise; no yardstick for 'enough'*

Version 1.0 · 28 October 2026
Status: draft, pending right of reply
Prepared from public sources, NSO and Eurostat data.
Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT
Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 21 July 2026 the Malta Chamber of Commerce, Enterprise and Industry said of the July power cuts that **“this increase was predictable – given the trends in increase in population”** and that **“It is evident that the investment carried out was not enough”**. The Chamber gave no figures. We tested what can be tested from public data: whether the rise in demand was foreseeable, and how much of it population explains. The sufficiency of investment could not be tested from documents we could open.

1. **The rise in peak demand was visible in the trend.** A straight line fitted to the NSO’s annual peaks for 2017–2022 gives 631 MW for 2025; the actual peak was 637 MW. Peaks rose in 5 of the 8 years from 2018 to 2025.
2. **Population explains about a third of it, not most.** Peak demand rose 42.6% from 2018 to 2023 (465 to 663 MW); residents plus peak-month tourists rose 13.4%. Had peak demand per person present stayed at the 2018 level, the 2023 peak would have been about 527 MW, so people present account for about 31% of the 198 MW rise.
3. **The Chamber also names tourists and climate.** Its statement, as we could read it, lists population, tourist numbers and rising temperatures; the quoted phrase singles out population. The hottest month at Luqa was 2.5 °C warmer in 2023 than in 2018.
4. **‘Investment was not enough’ has no yardstick.** Neither the Chamber nor any document we could open gives the investment needed. The National Audit Office’s 2024 review is reported to find high-voltage capital spending falling from about EUR 15 million a year to EUR 5.7 million in 2023 (second-hand; we could not open it). The Government says EUR 161 million was invested since 2022 . Neither settles ‘enough’.
5. **Verdict: not substantiated (low confidence).** The foreseeability limb holds up; the investment limb is a judgement we could not test first-hand.



+42.6%
Peak demand 2018 to 2023 (465 to 663 MW), NSO

+13.4%
Residents plus peak-month tourists, same years, Eurostat

31%
Share of the 2018–2023 rise in peak demand accounted for by more people present

631 MW
2025 peak predicted by the 2017–2022 trend (actual: 637 MW)

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP
The investment actually made in the distribution network, set against a stated need (a planning standard or Enemalta’s own load forecast), showing a shortfall; or the NAO review’s figures read in full.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN
Evidence that spending matched the network’s planned needs and that the July 2026 faults had causes unrelated to capacity, such as the fault-cause analysis the Government has cited.

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify
2 Method
3 What the data show
4 Where the evidence points different ways
5 Testing the claim
6 Verdict and requests for evidence
7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The statement is a press statement of the Malta Chamber, published by Business Now on 21 July 2026 [1], headed ‘Predictable strain, unacceptable disruption’. A fuller reader’s extract of the page (28 Oct 2026) confirmed the sentence on investment and the date; the other two phrases were read on 25 Oct 2026. Both were read through a web reader, not a saved copy, so the quoted words should be checked against the page. Where the Chamber’s words are not in quotation marks below, they are our paraphrase.

What was said	Who	Access
“this increase was predictable – given the trends in increase in population”	Malta Chamber [1]	Via web reader (intake, 25 Oct 2026)
“It is evident that the investment carried out was not enough”	Malta Chamber [1]	Via web reader, 25 and 28 Oct 2026
The cuts are “linked directly with the country’s economic growth model”	Malta Chamber [1]	Via web reader (intake, 25 Oct 2026)
Population, tourist numbers and rising temperatures “place additional and predictable pressures” on infrastructure (reader’s extract; not rated)	Malta Chamber [1]	Via web reader, 28 Oct 2026

SCOPE NOTE
This check covers the measurable parts: whether the rise in demand was foreseeable and what population explains, and what is known about investment. The Chamber’s view that the cuts follow from the country’s growth model is a characterisation and is not rated. We do not test who caused the July 2026 faults (see CC-027).

2 Method

Question. Was the rise in electricity demand foreseeable from past trends, how much of it do population and tourists account for, and is there evidence that investment was or was not enough?

Evidence. Annual peak demand (the highest monthly maximum) from the National Statistics Office’s Electricity Supply releases 2017–2025 [2]; Eurostat population (demo_gind), tourist nights (tour_occ_nim) and final electricity consumption (nrg_cb_e) [3]; NOAA GHCN-Daily temperatures at Luqa [4]. Tourists present are peak-month nights divided by 31, the method of the IMF’s paper in CC-135. These are the same inputs, copied to *data/cc-137/* with their retrieval dates, and all numbers are recomputed by *tools/cc-137-report/calc.py*. For investment we found only second-hand reports (◆) [5][6].

Foreseeability test. We fit a straight line to the annual peaks for 2017–2022 only, as a forecaster would have had them before the 2023 peak, and compare its extension with the actual peaks. This is a plausibility test of ‘predictable’, not a forecasting model.

Grades. Official statistics are grade C; the Chamber’s statement and reports of documents we did not open are grade D. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the data show

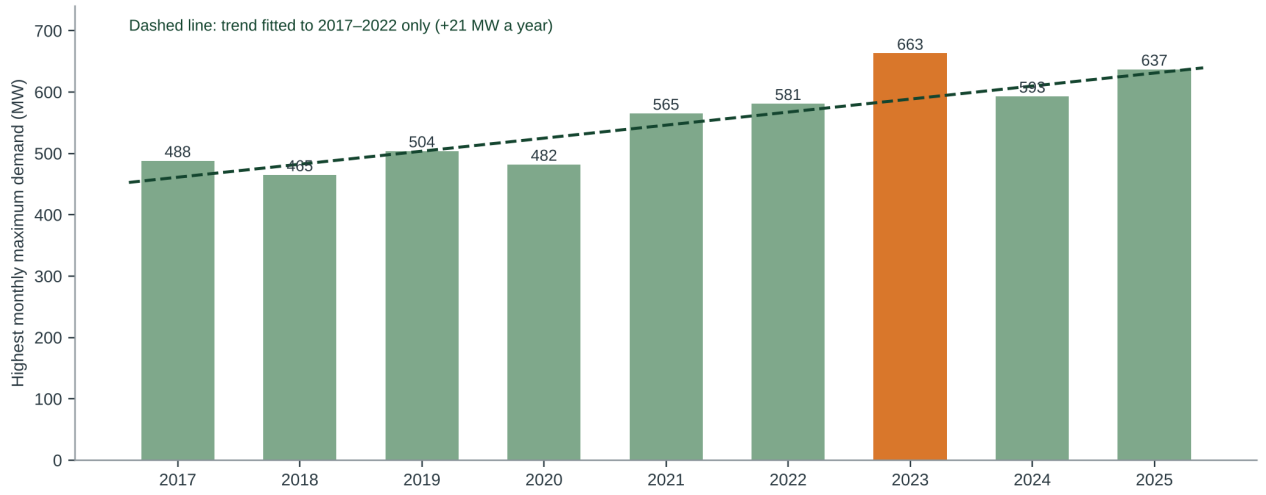


Figure 1. Annual peak electricity demand in Malta, 2017–2025 (NSO), with a trend line fitted to 2017–2022 only. The 2023 peak (orange) is above the line; 2024 fell back and 2025 is on it.

Indicator	Value	Source	Grade
Peak demand 2018 → 2023	465 → 663 MW (**+42.6%**)	NSO [2]	C
Residents plus peak-month tourists 2018 → 2023	**+13.4%**	Eurostat [3]	C
Residents alone (annual average) 2018 → 2023	+14.2%	Eurostat [3]	C
Final electricity consumption 2018 → 2023	+13.4%	Eurostat [3]	C
Peak per person present, 2018 → 2023	0.89 → 1.12 kW (+25.7%)	NSO; Eurostat	C
2023 peak if peak per person had stayed at the 2018 level	527 MW; people present explain **31%** of the rise	calculated	C
Trend 2017–2022, extended to 2023 and 2025	588 MW (actual 663) and 631 MW (actual 637)	calculated from NSO	C
Years with a higher peak than the year before, 2018–2025	5 of 8	NSO [2]	C
Hottest-month mean temperature at Luqa	26.9 °C (2018); 29.4 °C (2023); 28.1 °C (2025)	NOAA [4]	C

All values are in data/cc-137/checks.csv. The NSO series was transcribed through a web reader because nso.gov.mt refuses scripts; the 2022–2025 values come from the releases' text and may have been revised (see CC-135).

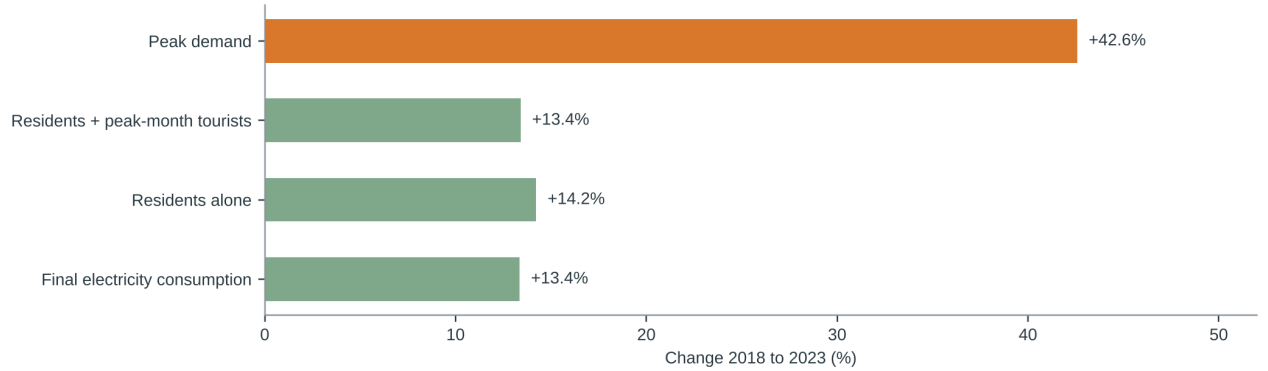


Figure 2. Growth 2018 to 2023: peak demand against the number of people present and energy used. Energy and people grew together; the peak grew about three times as fast.

Two readings follow. First, a rising peak was not a surprise: it was the established direction. Second, population is not what drove most of the rise in the peak: energy use tracked population, while the peak per person present rose by about a quarter. CC-135 shows that the end years 2018 and 2023 are the coolest and hottest summers of the period, which makes 2018–2023 the steepest window; the IMF paper treated temperature as a possible part of the explanation.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Was the rise in demand predictable? — YES, AS A TREND

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Peaks rose in 5 of 8 years; the 2017–2022 trend gave 631 MW for 2025 against an actual 637 MW. The IMF's February 2025 paper already reported the 43% rise and a 30% further rise projected by 2040 (CC-135).

EVIDENCE AGAINST

A single hot summer is hard to foresee: the 2023 peak was 12.7% above the 2017–2022 trend, and 2024 fell below it. The July 2026 peak of 741 MW reported elsewhere (CC-027) is not verified.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: 'predictable' holds as a direction and rough rate; it does not hold for the size of any one summer's peak.

Q2 Does population explain the increase? — ONLY IN PART

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

People present grew 13.4% from 2018 to 2023, and energy use grew 13.4%. Population is a real driver of the base load.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The peak grew 42.6%. At constant peak per person the 2023 peak would have been 527 MW, 136 MW short of the actual 663 MW. Temperature, air-conditioning use and the peak-month mix are not separated here.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: 'given the trends in increase in population' is a partial explanation; the Chamber's fuller text also names tourists and temperature.

Q3 Was the investment carried out enough? NOT TESTABLE FROM WHAT WE COULD OPEN

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

The National Audit Office's review of July 2024 is reported (The Shift, MaltaToday summaries ◆) to find high-voltage capital investment falling from an average of about EUR 15 million a year in 2014–2018 to EUR 5.7 million in 2023, and actual spending below budget, while demand rose.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The Government says EUR 161 million was invested in distribution since 2022 and that the July 2026 problem was the distribution network under heat, not generation (CC-027, reported speech ◆). Enemalta disputed the NAO's reading in 2024 (reported ◆). No source gives the investment the network needed.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the direction of the 2014–2023 reports is consistent with 'not enough', but 'enough' needs a benchmark, and the post-2023 spending is only the Government's figure.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. "this increase was predictable"	The 2017–2022 trend gave 631 MW for 2025 (actual 637); peaks rose in 5 of 8 years [2].	SUPPORTED
B. "given the trends in increase in population"	People present +13.4% against peak demand +42.6%; they account for about 31% of the 2018–2023 rise [2][3].	PARTLY
C. "It is evident that the investment carried out was not enough"	No figure for investment made or needed in the statement; NAO findings known second-hand only ◆ [5][6].	NOT SUBSTANTIATED
D. Cuts "linked directly with the country's economic growth model"	A characterisation; not rated.	NOT RATED

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

The rise was foreseeable; 'investment was not enough' is stated without a yardstick. Confidence: low.

Why. (1) The foreseeability limb is backed by NSO and Eurostat data. (2) Population alone explains only about a third of the rise in the peak, so 'given the trends in population' understates the other drivers the Chamber itself lists. (3) The sufficiency of investment, the most consequential part, is stated as evident but supported by no figure in the statement, and the documents that bear on it (the NAO review, Enemalta's accounts) were not readable by us. A statement whose central judgement cannot be tested stays 'not substantiated', not 'contradicted': the second-hand reports point the same way as the Chamber. Confidence is low because the key evidence is second-hand.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say the Chamber is wrong, that investment was adequate, or who is responsible for the cuts. It says the sufficiency claim has not been shown on documents we could read. It is a draft pending right of reply.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The Chamber's basis for 'investment was not enough': the figures it relied on.
- ☐ The NAO's 'High-Level Review on Enemalta's Planning and Investment in the Local Distribution Network' (July 2024), in full, and Enemalta's yearly distribution capital expenditure 2019–2026.

☐ Enemalta's or the regulator's load forecast and planning standard for the distribution network.

7 Limitations

- The Chamber's statement was read only through a web reader; its wording should be checked against the page (Business Now returns 403 to scripts). The sentence introducing 'this increase' was paraphrased by the reader as 'an increased demand increases strain', not quoted.
- The NAO review, MaltaToday and Malta Business Weekly returned 403 or 503; the NAO figures come from a Shift article and search summaries (◆), and the EUR 5.7 million and EUR 15 million figures are the outlets' reports of the review, not the review's text.
- Search log (28 Oct 2026): Enemalta or Government distribution investment for 2024–2026 was searched on the web (one query); no 2025–2026 figure was found beyond the Government's EUR 161 million (CC-027). Enemalta's annual accounts were not searched.
- The foreseeability test is a straight line on nine annual peaks; it does not separate temperature, air-conditioning, or the peak month's tourists. Peak demand 2022–2025 was transcribed from release texts.
- Outage records and Enemalta reliability indices were not obtained, so the link between investment and the July 2026 cuts is not tested.

References

[1] Malta Chamber of Commerce, Enterprise and Industry (21 Jul 2026). Predictable strain, unacceptable disruption: Malta Chamber urges immediate action over power cuts. *Business Now*. https://businessnow.mt/predictable-strain-unacceptable-disruption-malta-chamber-urges-immediate-action-over-power-cuts/

[2] National Statistics Office Malta. Electricity Supply, news releases 2022–2026 (maximum demand). Transcribed 26 Oct 2026; see data/cc-137/nso_max_demand.csv. https://nso.gov.mt/

[3] Eurostat. demo_gind, tour_occ_nim, nrg_cb_e; retrieved 26 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/

[4] NOAA NCEI. GHCN-Daily, station MT000016597 (Luqa); retrieved 26 Oct 2026. https://www.ncei.noaa.gov/data/global-historical-climatology-network-daily/access/MT000016597.csv

[5] ◆ The Shift (16 Jul 2024). NAO confirmed 2023 electricity failure was result of lack of investment in grid. Reports the NAO review; read via web reader, review not opened. https://theshiftnews.com/2024/07/16/confirmed-2023-electricity-failure-was-result-of-lack-of-investment-in-grid/

[6] ◆ National Audit Office (15 Jul 2024). High-Level Review on Enemalta's Planning and Investment in the Local Distribution Network. Page and PDF returned 403; known from search summaries only. https://nao.gov.mt/2024/07/15/high-level-review-on-enemaltas-planning-and-investment-in-the-local-distribution-network/

[7] Miżien. CC-135 (IMF on peak demand) and CC-027 (Government account of the July 2026 cuts). Data and calculations: data/cc-137/; tools/cc-137-report/calc.py.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate**: evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low**: evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ◆ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline,** with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it,** and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify,** and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	28 Oct 2026	First issue.